

Overclock Your Graphics Card—Without A Crash!

Every month, Digit will pose a question that will set you thinking. Digit challenges the geek in you to take a crack at the problem. If you indeed crack it, send in your answers to Digit with your full name, address and contact details to takeacrack@thinkdigit.com. Digit's Test Centre will select the correct answers. In case of multiple correct entries, the winner will be decided by a draw of lots.



Solution

Before you proceed, remember that overclocking your video card nullifies its warranty.

To overclock your video card, use EnTech Taiwan's Powerstrip (<http://www.entehtaiwan.com/ftp/pstrip.exe>) and test whether the speed is safe using Artifact Tester (<http://www.3dcht4u.de/3dc/kfd53t5fes8z/artifact-tester.zip>).

First, ensure that no programs are running in the background. Start PowerStrip, click on its system tray icon and go to Performance profiles > Configure. The 'Performance profiles' dialogue has two sliders: one on the left to adjust the clock speed of the GPU and the other to adjust that of the video memory.

Move the sliders up to overclock. Avoid taking long strides; increase the clock speed by 4 MHz at a time and click OK or Apply. Initially, increase both the video chip and memory clock speed in this manner. You can overclock most video cards to achieve

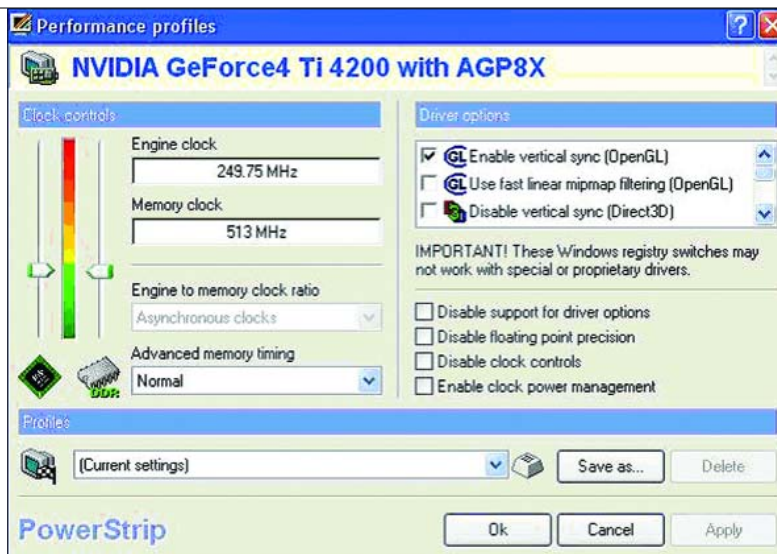
speeds that are around 10 per cent above their default specifications.

A video card overclocked above its safety limits shows artifacts—random dots and lines on the monitor. Unpack the artifact-tester.zip file to a folder and run ArtifactTester5.exe from that folder.

Powerstrip lets you load and select performance profiles

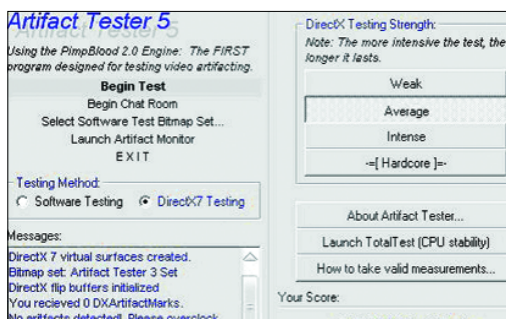
Use PowerStrip to overclock your video card by 4 MHz. Now, click on 'Begin Test' in Artifact Tester. The bottom right of the window indicates if any artifacts were detected, when the test completes. For a start, select 'Average' under 'DirectX Testing Strength.'

You may also want to use software testing methods to be completely sure that artifacts are not produced. Increase the clock speed if it does not detect arti-



Last Month's Challenge Was:

Can you overclock your graphics card safely without causing a crash? The winner of the Microsoft keyboard and mouse is Jayesh C. Limaye. Congratulations, Jayesh! His solution is published below...



Artifact Tester diagnoses whether the performance boost leads to artifacts

facts. If it detects some, then lower the clock speed by 1 or 2 MHz and test again. Note the final stable clock speeds. This is the 'absolute maximum clock speed' (AMCS) that your video card can safely reach.

If your system freezes, return to the previous clock speed value and take that value as the AMCS.

You may also launch the Artifact Monitor by clicking on 'Launch Artifact Monitor', located at the upper left of the monitoring application. Keep this window open as you go about detecting artifacts while overclocking the video card.

To be on the safe side, lower clock speeds by around 4 MHz below the AMCS since the video card tends to get heated when playing 3D games and may produce artifacts during game play or worse, get fried. Overclock the video card above the AMCS only if you have a PC cabinet with proper ventilation and use a cooling solution for your video card such as a better heat sink/ fan combination.

Additionally, ATI card owners can use the ATI Tool (<http://atitool.ocfaq.com/>), whereas nVidia card owners can employ Riva Tuner (<http://www.guru3d.com/rivatuner>) and NV Hardpage (<http://www.guru3d.com/nvhardpage>). Use these only if you are adept at overclocking.

THIS MONTH'S CHALLENGE

Insert an item in the menu that opens as you right-click on a Web page in Internet Explorer



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Rules and Regulations

- ☑ Readers are requested to send in their answers by the 15th of the month of publication.
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